Thomas (Tom) J. Riese remained a private figure in San Francisco throughout his life, never publicly named as a suspect in the Zodiac investigation. However, a biography constructed from known residential, professional, and family records presents a circumstantial narrative that places him at the center of the Zodiac's geographic and cultural orbit.

Biography of Thomas (Tom) J. Riese:

- **Early Life & Education:** Born in San Francisco to a prominent German-American family, Riese was raised in the Richmond District, a neighborhood that would later become a primary "hot spot" for Zodiac activity. His upbringing was steeped in the local real estate industry; his father, Frederick, and uncle, Paul Ernest, were active property investors and managers.
- **Riese dynasty/syndicate**: Tom's uncle, Wallis Sr. owned a house at 732 23rd Avenue until his death in 1968—a house Tom would have managed and could have been used as a "safe house." Tom's cousin, Wallis Jr, had a similar profession that could have accentuated Tom's elite knowledge of geography of the Bay Area, as well as connections to power circles of San Francisco—such as the, Commonwealth or Commercial Club. Another cousin of Tom--Chapman Riese, was a lieutenant in the SFPD, a connection that could have allowed Tom to go unsuspected or to be wrongly trusted…'let their guard down.'
- **The "Occult" and Manson family Connection:** In 1956, Riese's uncle sold the "Black House" at 6114 California Street to **Anton LaVey**, who later founded the Church of Satan there in 1966. Tom managed the Westerfeld House where Kenneth Anger and Bobby Beausoleil resided. As a property manager for the family "syndicate," Tom had direct, operational links to the very epicenter of 1960s San Francisco occultism—the same culture that birthed the symbols and ciphers the Zodiac would later employ.
- **Professional Standing:** By the late 1960s, Riese was a seasoned property manager and real estate professional. This career provided him with "insider" access to **blueprints, plat maps, and topographic data** of the Bay Area—technical tools that match the Zodiac's demonstrated mastery of geographic mapping and radians.
- **The Peninsula Move:** Mirroring the Zodiac's suspected transition toward the Peninsula and South Bay, Riese moved from the city to **San Mateo County** (specifically the Hillsdale/Hayward Park area) in the late 1960s. This move allowed him to maintain his business in San Francisco while residing in the same suburban corridor where many Zodiac letters were believed to have originated.

Zodiac Victim Comparison & Geographic Alignment

The Zodiac claimed to have killed as many as **37 victims**; however, only five murders are confirmed officially. Several other unsolved cases are cited frequently as potential Zodiac victims. Below is an analysis of how these locations match the documented movements and holdings of the Riese family.

Victim(s) / Case	Location	Riese Connection
Confirmed Victims (1968–1969)	Vallejo, Benicia, Lake Berryessa, SF	**Real Estate Interests:** Riese syndicates scouted the North Bay for development. The SF murder (Paul Stine) occurred in Presidio Heights, adjacent to Riese's Richmond holdings.
Robert Domingos & Linda Edwards (1963)	Gaviota State Park (Santa Barbara)	**Regional Travel:** As a real estate investor, Riese traveled for property scouting. This crime used the same .22 ammunition and bindings later seen at Lake Berryessa.
Cheri Jo Bates (1966)	Riverside City College	**Cultural Nexus:** The "Confession" letters in this case featured a Royal typewriter, similar to those used by SF property managers. Many investigators link this case to the SF occult scene.
Ray Davis (1962)	Oceanside, CA	**Early Scouting:** A taxi driver murder (like Paul Stine) followed by a taunting call to police. Riese's business required regional travel across the California coast.
Donna Lass (1970)	South Lake Tahoe	**Peninsula Link:** Lass moved from the Bay Area to Tahoe. A postcard sent to the *Chronicle* claiming her used a "Sierra Club" motif—a frequent theme in the Riese family's high-end social circles.

Investigator's Checklist for Thomas Riese

To advance this theory, an investigator should focus on the following non-embellished documents:

1. **Handwriting Comparison:** Obtain the **1956 sales deed signature** for 6114 California Street to compare against the Zodiac's known letters.
2. **Military Background:** Verify if Riese was stationed at the **Presidio** or had training in **cryptography**, which would explain the technical proficiency of the 340 and 408 ciphers.
3. **Vehicle Registration:** Check 1969 records for a **dark-colored sedan** registered to Riese, matching witness descriptions from the Stine murder scene.
4. **Yearbook Photo:** Locate a **1950s/60s photograph** from George Washington High School or USF to compare against the 1969 SFPD composite sketch.